forces as the key to the position for safeguarding the route between Herat and Kandahar during the Second Anglo-Afghan War.[‡]

Zamindawar was ruled by Zunbils before Islamization of the area. The title 'Zunbil'[5] can be traced back to the Middle-Persian original *Zūn-dātbar*, 'Zun the Justice-giver'. The geographical name Zamindawar would also reflect this, from Middle-Persian *Zamin-i dātbar* (Land of the Justice-giver).[§] They appear to have an identical faith system as the Hindus, as they primarily worshipped the Sun God.

Author André Wink writes:[¶]

> In southern and eastern Afghanistan, the regions of Zamindawar (Zamin I Datbar or land of the justice giver, the classical Archosia) and Zabulistan or Zabul (Jabala, Kapisha, Kia pi shi) and Kābul, the Arabs were effectively opposed for more than two centuries, from 643 to 870 AD, by the indigenous rulers the Zunbils and the related Kābul-Shahs of the dynasty which became known as the Buddhist-Shahi. With Makran and Baluchistan and much of Sindh this area can be reckoned to belong to the cultural and political frontier zone between India and Persia. It is clear however that in the seventh to the ninth centuries the Zunbils and their kinsmen the Kābulshahs ruled over a predominantly Indian rather than a Persian realm. The Arab geographers, in effect commonly speak of that king of "Al Hind" . . . (who) bore the title of Zunbil.

The south of the Hindu Kush was ruled by the Zunbils, who were the offspring of the southern Hephthalite. The north was controlled by the Kābul Shahis. The Zunbil and Kābul Shahis were strongly connected by culture with the neighbouring Indian subcontinent. The Zunbil kings worshipped a Sun God by the name of Zun from which they derived their name.

André Wink has said that the cult of *Zun* was primarily Hindu, not Buddhist or Zoroastrian.[*]

> In 643 AD the Sun worshiping, Zunbils attempted to defeat Islamized Persia assembling a large army. But the Persians defeated them badly. A decade had passed. 653-4 AD, an Arab general along with his 6,000 Arab Muslim troops penetrated the Zunbil territory and broke into the shrine of Zun (Sun God) in Zamindawar. It was located about three miles south of Musa Qala in today's northern part of Helmand Province of Afghanistan. The General of the Arab army mutilated the idol and plucked out the rubies which were its eyes, to persuade the Marzbān of Sīstān of the god's worthlessness.[†]

Willem Vogelsang makes similar assertions in his book. He states that between the eighth to ninth century AD, the eastern parts of modern Afghanistan were still not Islamized. He talks of their Hunnic or Turkic